

doc-trinity

Affirms · Theology Proper › Trinity · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: high

Statement under examination

There is one God eternally existing in three coequal, coeternal, distinct Persons: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Rationale

Pan-canonical lexical pattern: strict monotheism (Deut 6:4, Isa 45:5 H3068, H430) coexists with full deity predicated of the Son (John 1:1 theos G2316 as predicate of the logos; John 20:28 ho theos G2316 in vocative addressed to the risen Jesus; Col 2:9 theotes G2320; Heb 1:8 ho theos G2316 spoken by the Father to the Son) and of the Spirit (Acts 5:3-4 parallel: lying to the Holy Spirit IS lying to God; 2 Cor 3:17 the Lord IS the Spirit). Personal distinction is canonical (Matt 3:16-17 three actors at the baptism; Matt 28:19 singular onoma G3686 over three referents; 2 Cor 13:14 triadic benediction; John 14-16 sending pattern Father to Son to Spirit). The canon refuses both modalist collapse and tritheist division.

Reasoning

The Bible teaches that there is only one God. Deuteronomy 6:4 says Hear O Israel, the LORD our God, the LORD is one. Isaiah 45:5 says I am the LORD, and there is no other God besides me. So whatever else is true, only one God exists. The Bible also calls the Father God, calls Jesus the Son God, and treats the Holy Spirit as God. In John 1:1 the Word was with God and the Word was God, and that Word becomes flesh as Jesus. In John 20:28 Thomas looks at the risen Jesus and says my Lord and my God, and Jesus accepts the words instead of correcting them. In Hebrews 1:8 the Father speaks to the Son and calls him God. In Acts 5:3-4 Peter tells Ananias he has lied to the Holy Spirit, and in the very next sentence says he has lied to God. At Jesus's baptism in Matthew 3:16-17 three are present at once: the Son in the water, the Spirit coming down as a dove, and the Father speaking from heaven. The honest counterargument is real. Critics point to Mark 13:32 where Jesus says he does not know the hour, and to John 14:28 where Jesus says the Father is greater than I. They say this proves Jesus is not fully God. The historic answer is that during his earthly life Jesus willingly took up a real human nature with real human limits, while still being God. He learned, he grew tired, he died. The Father is greater than the Son in mission and order, not in being. So the canon holds two truths together. There is only one God. That one God is the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Take away any of the three and the gospel itself breaks. Only God can save sinners; only God can dwell inside believers.

Denominational landscape

Agreement on the Trinity is unanimous across every tracked historic Christian lineage. The Catholic Church teaches one God in three persons of one substance. Eastern Orthodoxy and the Oriental Orthodox churches both confess the same doctrine; they differ from the West about the filioque clause but not about the underlying Trinity. Lutheran, Anglican, Reformed, Methodist, Anabaptist, and Pentecostal confessions all open with the same statement: one living and true God, three persons of one substance, power, and eternity, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. The patristic fathers (Athanasius, the Cappadocians, Augustine, Tertullian) defended the doctrine in the early centuries. The Nicene Creed of 325, completed at Constantinople in 381, is shared by Catholics, Orthodox, Anglicans, Lutherans, Reformed, and most Protestants. Public-record carriers of denial place themselves outside historic Christianity by their own claim. The Jehovah's Witnesses say the Trinity is unbiblical and identify Jesus as Michael the Archangel, a

created being, and the Holy Spirit as God's impersonal active force. The Christadelphians teach a similar position. Mormonism teaches three separate Gods, with the Father having a physical body, which is functionally polytheistic rather than Trinitarian. Oneness Pentecostals teach modalism, in which Father, Son, and Spirit are three modes of one person rather than three distinct persons. Unitarian Universalists reject all binding doctrine of God. Historic Arianism, condemned at Nicaea, is the prototype of all created-Son views. By every historic Christian standard, these movements teach a different God.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	Yes
Would visit if otherwise	No
Would participate if otherwise	No
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

The word Trinity is not in the Bible; the doctrine is the canonical lexical shape once the witness is read whole. Public-record carriers of explicit denial: Jehovah's Witnesses (Christ as Michael the Archangel, a created spirit being; Holy Spirit as impersonal active force), Christadelphians (Christ as a created Son, Spirit as God's power), Unitarian Universalists (no binding doctrine of God), Mormonism (three separate Gods, the Father with a physical body; functionally polytheistic), Oneness Pentecostals (modalism: one person manifesting in three modes; denies eternal personal distinction). Classical Arianism is the historic prototype condemned at Nicaea 325. The cult-marker line is canonical, not ecumenical: denying the Trinity breaks the gospel mediator structure (only a fully divine Son can reconcile creatures to God; only a fully divine Spirit can indwell believers and be the seal of redemption) and falsifies who God is.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

Grammatico-historical reading of the canonical lexical pattern is sufficient. No framework (covenantal, dispensational, new-covenant, progressive-covenantalism) produces a different verdict on the Trinity; this doctrine sits prior to every interpretive framework. Analogia scripturae is heavily invoked because the verdict rests on the whole canon (Deut 6:4, Isa 45:5, Gen 1:26, John 1:1, John 20:28, Col 2:9, Heb 1:8, Acts 5:3-4, Matt 3:16-17, Matt 28:19, 2 Cor 13:14) rather than any one passage. Progressive revelation is a factor in the sense that the personal distinctions inside the one God are made explicit only in the New Testament; the Old Testament strictly insists on the oneness, while the New Testament shows that this one God is the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. The OT passages are not retroactively read into Christian doctrine; they constrain it (monotheism cannot be broken), and the NT discloses what was always true of God's inner life. Competing-lens verdicts: none. Even subordinationist or Arian readings do not represent a different valid hermeneutical framework within historic Christianity; they are simply judged exegetically wrong by the canon-wide lexical pattern.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Deut.6.4 · **for** · genre: law

Key term. יהוה YHWH H3068; אלהינו elohenu H430; אחד echad H259

Force. The Shema: Hear O Israel, YHWH our God, YHWH is one. Echad H259 is the standard term for unity; same word names the unity of husband and wife as one flesh in Gen 2:24, indicating compound unity is within its semantic range. Establishes strict monotheism as the canonical floor.

Isa.45.5 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key term. יהוה YHWH H3068; אלהים elohim H430; אין ayin H369 (none); זולת zulah (besides)

Force. I am YHWH and there is no other; besides me there is no God. Repeated negation makes the monotheistic claim absolute. Whatever is true of the Son and the Spirit must be true within the one God, not as a second or third deity alongside.

Gen.1.26 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. אלהים elohim H430; נַעֲשֶׂה na-aseh (let us make, first-person plural cohortative of אָשָׁה asah H6213)

Force. Elohim (grammatically plural noun for the one true God) speaks let us make humanity in our image. The first-person plural cohortative inside the mouth of the one creator God hints at internal plurality. Honest reading: the grammar is open, not coercive; could be plural of majesty, divine council, or proto-Trinitarian. Recorded as supporting hint, not as the load-bearing proof.

John.1.1 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. λόγος logos G3056; θεός theos G2316; ἦν en G1510 (imperfect of εἰμι eimi)

Force. In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. First theos has the definite article (the Word was with the [Father] God); the predicate theos in clause three lacks the article. The qualitative force says the Word fully shares the nature of God while remaining distinct from the Father (the Word was WITH God). The imperfect tense en places this before all creation. John 1:14 identifies this Word as Jesus.

John.20.28 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. κύριος kyrios G2962; θεός theos G2316; both with the definite article ho

Force. Thomas to the risen Jesus: my Lord and my God (ho kyrios mou kai ho theos mou). Both nouns are articular. Jesus accepts the confession in v.29 (because you have seen me you have believed) without correction. The Father has nowhere been the referent in this scene; the addressee throughout is the risen Christ. Direct ascription of theos (G2316) to Jesus.

Col.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. πλήρωμα pleroma G4138; θεότης theotes G2320 (deity itself, not theiotes G2305 deity-like quality); σωματικῶς somatikos G4985 (bodily)

Force. In him (Christ) all the fullness of deity itself dwells bodily. Theotes G2320 is the strongest available Greek term for the divine essence; not theiotes which would mean divine quality. Paul predicates the whole essence of God of the bodily Jesus.

Heb.1.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. θρόνος thronos G2362; θεός theos G2316 (vocative ho theos)

Force. Quoting Ps 45:6-7, the Father speaks TO the Son: Your throne O God is forever and ever. The Father directly addresses the Son as God. The OT royal psalm is applied to Christ by the inspired writer; the appeal is to the lexical content of the Father's own speech.

Acts.5.3-4 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. πνεῦμα τὸ ἅγιον pneuma to hagian G4151 G40; θεός theos G2316; ψεύδομαι pseudomai G5574

Force. Peter v.3: why has Satan filled your heart to lie to the Holy Spirit. Peter v.4: you have not lied to men but to God. Same act, same lying-to dative; the apposition equates lying to the Holy Spirit with lying to God. The Spirit is here named God.

2Cor.3.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. κύριος kyrios G2962; πνεῦμα pneuma G4151

Force. Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom. Paul equates the Lord (the YHWH of the Exodus context he is exegeting from Exod 34) with the Spirit. Functional identification of the Spirit within the one divine identity.

Matt.3.16-17 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. πνεῦμα θεοῦ pneuma theou G4151 G2316; υἱός huios G5207 (the beloved Son); φωνή phone G5456 (the voice from heaven, the Father)

Force. At Jesus's baptism three actors appear simultaneously and distinctly: the Son in the water, the Spirit of God descending as a dove, the Father's voice from heaven naming the Son. Personal distinction is empirically displayed.

Matt.28.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. ὄνομα onoma G3686 (singular accusative); πατήρ pater G3962; υἱός huios G5207; ἅγιον πνεῦμα hagian pneuma G40 G4151

Force. Baptize them into THE NAME (singular onoma) of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. One name shared by three referents. Jesus, who has just identified himself as having all authority, places the Son and the Holy Spirit alongside the Father in the very baptismal formula that consecrates new disciples into the one God of Israel.

2Cor.13.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. χάρις charis G5485 (grace of the Lord Jesus Christ); ἀγάπη agape G26 (love of God, i.e. the Father); κοινωνία koinonia G2842 (fellowship of the Holy Spirit)

Force. Triadic benediction over the church. Three distinct giving-relationships, three named persons, one shared divine gift. Pauline doxology embeds the Trinitarian shape as devotional habit.

John.14.16-17 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. παράκλητος parakletos G3875 (another Helper); πατήρ pater G3962; πνεῦμα τῆς ἀληθείας pneuma tes aletheias G4151

Force. I will ask the Father and he will give you another Helper. Three persons in one sentence: the Son asks, the Father gives, the Spirit comes. Allos parakletos (another Helper of the same kind) implies the Spirit is another like Jesus, i.e. personal and divine.

1Cor.8.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. εἷς heis G1520 (one); θεός theos G2316 (the Father); κύριος kyrios G2962 (Jesus Christ)

Force. Paul's two-clause prayer redacts the Shema: one God the Father from whom are all things, and one Lord Jesus Christ through whom are all things. He splits the Shema's YHWH-Elohim across Father and Son while keeping the one. This is high-Christology, not subordinationism; Christ is placed inside the divine identity of the Shema itself.

John.10.30 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. ἓν hen G1520 (one, neuter, one thing not one person)

Force. I and the Father are one. The neuter hen rules out a modalist reading (would be heis, masculine) and rules out a merely-functional reading (the Jews pick up stones because they understand him to claim shared deity, v.33). Personal distinction (two, I and the Father) plus shared essence (one thing).

Mark.13.32 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key term. οἶδα oida G1492 (knows); υἱός huios G5207; πατήρ pater G3962

Force. Concerning that day or hour no one knows, not the angels, nor the Son, but only the Father. Used by Arians and JWs to argue ontological inferiority of the Son. Standard Trinitarian answer: communication of attributes during the incarnation; the Son in his assumed human nature does not access divine omniscience for that disclosure. The same Gospel of Mark predicates divine acts of Jesus (forgiving sin 2:5-12, stilling the storm 4:39, accepting worship). The complication is real but does not overturn the lexical pattern.

John.14.28 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key term. μείζων meizon G3187 (greater); πατήρ pater G3962

Force. The Father is greater than I. Used by Unitarians and Arians to argue ontological subordination. Trinitarian reading: functional and missional order, not essence; the sent Son is in submission to the sender in the work of redemption. John 1:1 (the Word was God) and John 10:30 (I and the Father are one) in the same Gospel forbid an ontological reading.

Col.1.15 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. πρωτότοκος prototokos G4416 (firstborn); εἰκών eikon G1504 (image)

Force. Firstborn of all creation. Used by JWs to argue Christ is a created being. Lexical answer: prototokos in the OT (Ps 89:27) denotes rank and inheritance, not chronological birth. The very next verses (Col 1:16-17) say all things were created by him and for him and in him all things hold together, which excludes him being among the created. Complicates only if the word is read against its canonical usage.

Prov.8.22 · complicates · genre: wisdom · figures: personification

Key term. קָנָה qanah H7069 (possessed/acquired); רֵשִׁית reshith H7225 (beginning)

Force. The LORD possessed me at the beginning of his way. Used by Arius (and later JW's) reading personified Wisdom as a created Son. The Hebrew qanah H7069 can mean possessed or brought forth or acquired; Arian translation as created is contested. Standard Trinitarian reading: this is poetic personification of divine Wisdom, later identified with Christ in 1 Cor 1:24 and Col 2:3. Complicates only on the Arian translation choice.

Rom.9.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. θεός theos G2316; εὐλογητός eulogetos G2128 (blessed)

Force. From them (Israel) according to the flesh is the Christ, who is over all, God blessed forever, amen. Direct ascription of theos to Christ; the doxology grammar in the most natural reading attaches theos to ho on epi panton (the one who is over all), naming Christ as God blessed forever.

Titus.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. θεός theos G2316; σωτήρ soter G4990; Granville-Sharp construction

Force. Awaiting the blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ. Two nouns under one article in Greek (tou megalou theou kai soterou) name one referent: Jesus Christ as our great God and Savior.

2Pet.1.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. θεός theos G2316; σωτήρ soter G4990; Granville-Sharp construction

Force. By the righteousness of our God and Savior Jesus Christ. Same single-article two-noun construction as Titus 2:13; one referent, Jesus Christ named as God and Savior.

Concordance lemmas traversed

H3068, H430, H259, H369, H6213, H7069, H7225, G2316, G2962, G4151, G40, G3056, G1510, G3686, G3962, G5207, G2320, G2305, G4138, G4985, G5574, G3875, G1520, G5485, G26, G2842, G3187, G4416, G1504, G2128, G4990, G2362

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Nicene Creed (325) and Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creed (381), CCEL Schaff Creeds of Christendom · affirms · verified

"We believe in one God, the Father almighty; and in one Lord Jesus Christ, the only-begotten Son of God, consubstantial with the Father; and in the Holy Spirit, the Lord and Giver of life."

patristic · Athanasian Creed (Quicumque Vult), CCEL · affirms · verified

"We worship one God in Trinity, and Trinity in Unity; Neither confounding the Persons: nor dividing the Substance."

patristic · Athanasius, Discourses Against the Arians, NPNF Series 2 Vol 4 (CCEL) · affirms · unverified

"The Son is of the same essence (homoousios) as the Father, eternally begotten, not made. He is the perfect Image of the Father, not a created being."

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church, paragraphs 232-267 (the dogma of the Holy Trinity); CCC 253: The Trinity is One · affirms · unverified

“We do not confess three Gods, but one God in three persons, the consubstantial Trinity. The divine persons are really distinct from one another.”

lutheran · Augsburg Confession (1530), Article I, Of God; bookofconcord.org · affirms · verified

“There is one Divine Essence; and yet there are three Persons, of the same essence and power, who also are coeternal, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost.”

anglican · Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion (1571), Article I, Of Faith in the Holy Trinity · affirms · unverified

“There is but one living and true God; And in unity of this Godhead there be three Persons, of one substance, power, and eternity; the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost.”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), Chapter 2, paragraph 3 · affirms · unverified

“In the unity of the Godhead there be three Persons of one substance, power, and eternity: God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Ghost.”

methodist · Methodist Articles of Religion (Wesley's abridgement of the 39 Articles), Article I · affirms · verified

“There is but one living and true God; And in unity of this Godhead there are three persons, of one substance, power, and eternity, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost.”

anabaptist · Dordrecht Confession of Faith (1632), Article I, Of God and the Creation of All Things · affirms · unverified

“We believe in one eternal, almighty, and incomprehensible God, Father, Son, and Holy Ghost; in three persons or being, coequal in power, glory, majesty, and dominion.”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God, Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 2, The One True God / The Adorable Godhead · affirms · unverified

“The one true God has revealed Himself as the eternally self-existent I AM, the Creator; and has further revealed Himself as embodying the principles of relationship and association as Father, Son, and Holy Ghost.”

eastern_orthodox · Orthodox Church in America, Doctrine: The Holy Trinity (the Nicene Creed as confessed in the Divine Liturgy) · affirms · unverified

“We baptize in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. The Father is the source; the Son is eternally begotten; the Spirit eternally proceeds. One God in three persons.”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/john/1-1.htm>

“John 1:1: kai theos en ho logos. Predicate theos (G2316) lacks the article; the Word fully shares divine nature. The first theos with article distinguishes the Father.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/john/20-28.htm>

“John 20:28: ho kyrios mou kai ho theos mou. Both ho kyrios (G2962) and ho theos (G2316) are articular, addressed by Thomas directly to the risen Jesus.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/colossians/2-9.htm>

“Col 2:9: en auto katoikei pan to pleroma tes theotetos somatikos. Theotes G2320 is the strongest available term for the divine essence; the whole of it dwells in Christ bodily.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/hebrews/1-8.htm>

“Heb 1:8: ho thronos sou ho theos. Father directly addresses the Son as God (vocative ho theos G2316). Quotes Ps 45:6-7 applied to Christ.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/5-3.htm>

“Acts 5:3-4: pseusasthai se to pneuma to hagion ... ouk epeuso anthropois alla to theo. Same dative; the Holy Spirit is named God by direct apposition.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/matthew/28-19.htm>

“Matt 28:19: eis to onoma (singular accusative G3686) tou patros kai tou huiou kai tou hagiou pneumatos. One name, three referents.”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_corinthians/13-14.htm

“2 Cor 13:14: charis (G5485) tou kyriou ... agape (G26) tou theou ... koinonia (G2842) tou hagiou pneumatos. Triadic benediction; three persons, one shared blessing.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/deuteronomy/6-4.htm>

“Deut 6:4: shema yisrael YHWH (H3068) eloheinu (H430) YHWH echad (H259). Strict monotheism; echad covers compound unity (cf. Gen 2:24 one flesh).”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/isaiah/45-5.htm>

“Isa 45:5: ani YHWH ve-ein od; zulati ein elohim. I am YHWH and there is none else; besides me there is no God. Monotheism is absolute.”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_corinthians/8-6.htm

“1 Cor 8:6: heis theos ho pater ... kai heis kyrios Iesous Christos. Paul splits the Shema's YHWH-Elohim across Father and Son while preserving the one.”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/of-god/>

“Augsburg I: There is one Divine Essence; yet three Persons of the same essence and power, coeternal: the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost.”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“Methodist Article I: There is but one living and true God; and in unity of this Godhead there are three persons, of one substance, power, and eternity, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Ghost.”

supports · category: patristic_archive · <https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/creeds2/creeds2.iv.i.iv.html>

“Athanasian Creed: we worship one God in Trinity, and Trinity in Unity; Neither confounding the Persons: nor dividing the Substance.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/matthew/3-16.htm>

“Matt 3:16-17: Jesus from the water, the Spirit of God (G4151 G2316) descending as a dove, the voice of the Father from heaven. Three actors at once.”

nuance · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/hebrew/259.htm>

“H259 echad: properly united, i.e. one. Covers both numerical one and compound unity (Gen 2:24 one flesh; Ezra 2:64 the assembly together). The Shema's grammar is not closed against internal plurality of the one God.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/mark/13-32.htm>

“Mark 13:32: oude ho huios (G5207). The Son does not know the hour. Used by Arians; handled by communicatio idiomatum in the incarnation.”

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